



beloved cricket. He speaks with equal affection of his other dear friend Yusuf Hamied of Cipla. "He is doing such fine work providing inexpensive drugs to AIDS patients in Africa. I only wish the Indian Government would do something similar with him."

Mehta remains a gypsy, travelling wherever work takes him—one month in Los Angeles, three months in Israel, three months in Florence and at least one month traipsing around the world on holiday. "Nancy has a long list. We recently went to Vietnam. And last year, we went on a 10-hour boat ride on the Mekong River." The one dream remains: of opening a music school in the city he was born in and whose largest slum, Dharavi,

he is heartily ashamed of. "I would love the Government to put up a matching grant to the amount we raise for the school," he says, recounting how China promoted Western classical music by importing music professors. "And now all the great American orchestras have at least 10-15 Chinese musicians," he points out.

The world still excites him as it did in 1960. "I was quite alone in America then. I think Subramaniam Chandrasekhar and I were the only Indians then. There was just one Indian restaurant in New York, called Kashmir. It was run by a Bangladeshi and even he refused to serve me during the 1971 war. I told him how can you do this when a Parsi field marshal is

giving you your freedom," he laughs, adding that he is an Indian first when he is abroad, but a Parsi first when he is in India. His interests remain eclectic. It could just be the pure spiritual pleasure that an audience gets while listening to a music performance for two-and-a-half hours. It could be dancer Alarmel Valli's performance, at his invitation, at the Munich Opera Festival. It could be the prospect of sitar maestro Pandit Ravi Shankar, who has written the foreword to his book, performing in Pakistan (think of the barriers it would break, he says joyously). It could even be the idea of taking the Israeli Philharmonic to Cairo.

Yes, even a maestro has some unfulfilled dreams. ■